STIVEN CATALYST

SECOND SERIES · NOVEMBER 2026

MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



KPIS

OEE: HOW MUCH OF THE CAPACITY IS REALLY USED

Nakajima's six big losses, where the world-class 85% comes from, what measured plants reach, three rates in one shift, OEE on a loading dock, what the logs hide, and a card for one asset.

65% was the average OEE of 884 machines in 23 Swedish companies in 2013–14, well below the 85% often called world class.

HEDMAN ET AL., 2016

INSIDE

COVER STORY
Where the capacity goes
PAGE 03

THE NUMBERS
World class and real plants
PAGE 04

TOOL OF THE ISSUE
The OEE card
PAGE 08

NO. 48 · KPIS

In this issue

A plant, a dock or a fleet can be busy all day and still deliver only part of what it could. Overall equipment effectiveness was built to show how much. Where does its famous target come from, and how far does the measure carry outside the factory?

In Seiichi Nakajima's total productive maintenance, OEE multiplies three rates: availability, performance and quality. His ideal conditions give 85%, the figure later called world class. Studies of real machines found about 55%, 60% and 65%. A study of road freight measured 54% for vehicles. And the data can mislead: in 884 Swedish machines, most performance and quality rates sat at the system's default of 100%.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

03 COVER STORY
Where the capacity goes

04 THE NUMBERS
World class and real plants

05 THE MODEL
Three rates, six losses

06 HOW IT TRANSFERS
From the machine to the dock

07 HOW IT IS MEASURED
Count before you compare

08 TOOL OF THE ISSUE
The OEE card for one asset

09 SOURCES
Sources and method

HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

Where the capacity goes

OEE grew out of total productive maintenance (TPM), which the Japan Institute of Plant Maintenance proposed in 1971. Its aim is zero losses; OEE shows how many remain.

1964
A maintenance group in Japan creates the PM Prize for plant maintenance.

1971
The body that became JIPM proposes TPM.

1988
Nakajima's Introduction to TPM appears in English.

1994
The prize becomes the TPM Award; by JIPM's count, over 3,500 sites have won it.

In about 20 cases, Örjan Ljungberg found that performance losses dominated, while many companies watched the big breakdowns rather than small losses of speed and time. In data from 98 Swedish companies (2006–2012), Ylipää and colleagues found the same order: operational efficiency first, then availability.

OUR READING

A breakdown is loud and gets a meeting. A line running a little slow all week is silent, and costs more.

Sources: Japan Institute of Plant Maintenance (JIPM), 2021; Seiichi Nakajima, Productivity Press, 1988 (via Muchiri & Pintelon (2008); Bengtsson, Andersson & Ekström (2022)); Örjan Ljungberg, International Journal of Operations & Production Management 18(5), 1998 (via Abstract at Crossref); Torbjörn Ylipää, Anders Skoogh, Jon Bokrantz & Maheshwaran Gopalakrishnan, International Journal of Productivity and Performance Management 66(1), 2017 (via Abstract at Chalmers Research and IDEAS/RePEc)

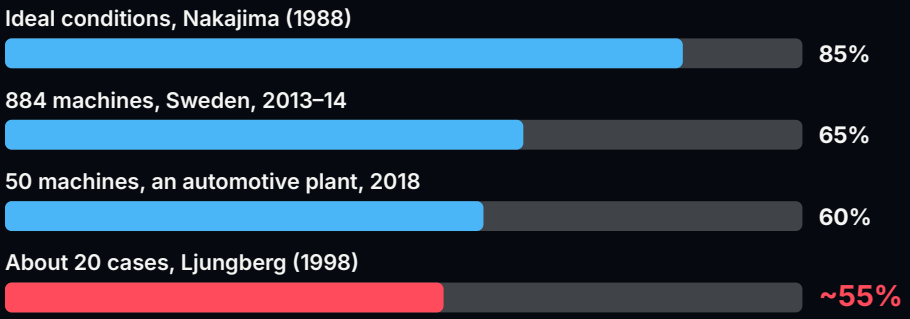
TPM and prize facts follow JIPM's own pages, in Japanese. Nakajima's book was not seen; its content is confirmed through journal articles that cite it.

THE NUMBERS

World class and real plants

Nakajima set out ideal conditions: availability above 90%, performance above 95%, quality above 99%. Multiplied, they give 85%, the level later authors call world class. Studies that measured real machines found less.

OEE: THE IDEAL AGAINST MEASURED AVERAGES



The 85% is a set of ideal conditions multiplied, not the average of a sample; we could not find who first called it world class. In the Swedish data the median was 70%: food and beverage plants averaged 74%, other automated discrete production 59%.

OUR READING

Against 85%, almost everyone looks bad and the number stops helping. Against last month, it shows whether the losses are shrinking.

Sources: Seiichi Nakajima, Productivity Press, 1988 (via Muchiri & Pintelon (2008); Bengtsson, Andersson & Ekström (2022)); Richard Hedman, Mukund Subramaniyan & Peter Almström, Procedia CIRP 57, 2016; Marcus Bengtsson, Lars-Gunnar Andersson & Pontus Ekström, Journal of Quality in Maintenance Engineering 28(2), 2022; Örjan Ljungberg, International Journal of Operations & Production Management 18(5), 1998 (via Abstract at Crossref)

Different samples, years and definitions: the bars show orders of magnitude and should not be read as a ranking. Nakajima's ideal as cited by Bengtsson et al. (2022).

THE MODEL

Three rates, six losses

OEE multiplies three rates; together they set good output against the planned time. Each rate collects two of Nakajima's six big losses.

01
Availability
running time against planned time; losses: breakdowns, setup and adjustment

02
Performance
output at ideal speed against running time; losses: idling and minor stops, reduced speed

03
Quality
good units against all units; losses: defects and rework, lower yield at start-up

INVENTED EXAMPLE, ONE SHIFT ON A PACKING LINE

Availability	480 planned minutes, 48 lost to stops: 90%
Performance	380 units at an ideal 1 minute each, in 432 minutes: 88%
Quality	370 of 380 good the first time: 97.4%
OEE	0.90 × 0.88 × 0.974 = 77.1%, or 370 good minutes of 480

No rate looks bad, yet almost a quarter of the shift is lost. Every figure here is made up.

A related measure, TEEP, divides by all calendar time instead of the planned time. A line that stands still every weekend can have a high OEE and a low TEEP.

Sources: Seiichi Nakajima, Productivity Press, 1988 (via Muchiri & Pintelon (2008); Bengtsson, Andersson & Ekström (2022)); Peter Muchiri & Liliane Pintelon, International Journal of Production Research 46(13), 2008 (via Submitted version on HAL)

Rates and losses follow Nakajima as Muchiri and Pintelon (2008) give them; the example is the editors'.

HOW IT TRANSFERS

From the machine to the dock

In 2004 David Simons, Robert Mason and Bernard Gardner carried OEE over to road freight as overall vehicle effectiveness (OVE), with five losses of its own. Their case study measured 54%; they put a target for the company at 70%.

01
Availability
the hours a dock door and its crew are ready, against the planned hours

02
Performance
pallets per hour against an agreed standard, not against the best day

03
Quality
loads right the first time: nothing reloaded, damaged or missing

In the Swedish plant data, about 90% of the stop time with a known cause was tied to support work done by operators, such as changeovers, adjustments and repairs, not to the automatic process itself.

OUR READING

A dock is more people, trucks and material than machine. A door waiting for a late truck stands idle through no fault of its own: log arrival losses on their own line, or the dock takes the blame for the yard.

Sources: David Simons, Robert Mason & Bernard Gardner, International Journal of Logistics: Research and Applications 7(2), 2004 (via Abstract at IAOR); Richard Hedman, Mukund Subramaniyan & Peter Almström, Procedia CIRP 57, 2016

Only the abstract of Simons et al. was seen, so we do not list their five losses. The dock version of the three rates is the editors' and has no published benchmark.

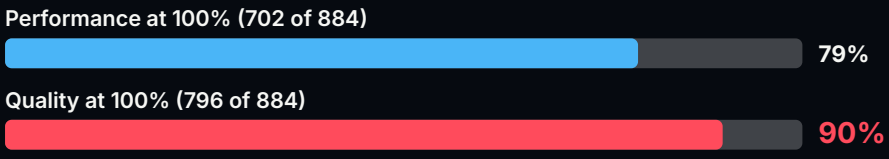
More in the essay High-volume days: the standard under pressure

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Count before you compare

An OEE is only as good as what is logged. Richard Hedman and colleagues examined the raw data behind automatic OEE measurement: 884 machines in 23 Swedish companies, over six months from October 2013.

MACHINES WHOSE LOGGED RATE WAS EXACTLY 100%, 2013–14



100% was the system's default. About half of the loss time had no usable cause: “unclassified” took 19% of the scheduled time. The authors ask whether such firms measure OEE or only availability.

In one automotive plant, 25 managers estimated the average OEE of the first half of 2018: 55% on average, from 40% to 66%. The logs said 60%. Four in five thought lack of material took more logged time than tool changes and quality checks; it did not.

Sources: Richard Hedman, Mukund Subramaniyan & Peter Almström, Procedia CIRP 57, 2016; Marcus Bengtsson, Lars-Gunnar Andersson & Pontus Ekström, Journal of Quality in Maintenance Engineering 28(2), 2022

Hedman et al. write “almost half” in the abstract and “more than half” in the results for the unclassified loss time; we write “about half”. The managers' survey covers a single plant.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The OEE card for one asset

One machine, door or vehicle, one week. Count against the planned time, give every stop a cause, and compare the result with last week, leaving 85% aside.

01	**Asset and planned time**	which one; planned minutes, not calendar minutes
02	**Availability**	running minutes ÷ planned minutes; each stop with its cause
03	**Performance**	units × ideal time per unit ÷ running minutes
04	**Quality**	good the first time ÷ all units
05	**OEE and the largest loss**	the three rates multiplied; which of the six losses took most
06	**Unclassified and one change**	minutes without a cause; what we change, when we count again

Sources: Peter Muchiri & Liliane Pintelon, International Journal of Production Research 46(13), 2008 (via Submitted version on HAL); Richard Hedman, Mukund Subramaniyan & Peter Almström, Procedia CIRP 57, 2016

The card is a practice the editors suggest, built on Nakajima's rates and losses and on the pitfalls Hedman et al. found.

Open the tool: Sigma & Control Chart stivencatalyst.com/tools/sigma-control-chart/

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

TPM to wa (What is TPM?) and Soshikizu/Enkaku (organisation and history), in Japanese
Japan Institute of Plant Maintenance (JIPM), 2021
https://www.jipm.or.jp/business/tpm/

Introduction to TPM: Total Productive Maintenance
Seiichi Nakajima, Productivity Press, 1988 · via Muchiri & Pintelon (2008); Bengtsson, Andersson & Ekström (2022)

Measurement of overall equipment effectiveness as a basis for TPM activities
Örjan Ljungberg, International Journal of Operations & Production Management 18(5), 1998 · via Abstract at Crossref
https://doi.org/10.1108/01443579810206334

Identification of maintenance improvement potential using OEE assessment
Torbjörn Ylipää, Anders Skoogh, Jon Bokrantz & Maheshwaran Gopalakrishnan, International Journal of Productivity and Performance Management 66(1), 2017 · via Abstract at Chalmers Research and IDEAS/RePEc
https://doi.org/10.1108/IJPPM-01-2016-0028

Analysis of critical factors for automatic measurement of OEE
Richard Hedman, Mukund Subramaniyan & Peter Almström, Procedia CIRP 57, 2016
https://doi.org/10.1016/j.procir.2016.11.023

Measuring preconceived beliefs on the results of overall equipment effectiveness – A case study in the automotive manufacturing industry
Marcus Bengtsson, Lars-Gunnar Andersson & Pontus Ekström, Journal of Quality in Maintenance Engineering 28(2), 2022
https://doi.org/10.1108/JQME-03-2020-0016

Performance measurement using overall equipment effectiveness (OEE): literature review and practical application discussion
Peter Muchiri & Liliane Pintelon, International Journal of Production Research 46(13), 2008 · via Submitted version on HAL
https://hal.science/hal-00512968

Overall vehicle effectiveness
David Simons, Robert Mason & Bernard Gardner, International Journal of Logistics: Research and Applications 7(2), 2004 · via Abstract at IAOR
https://doi.org/10.1080/1367556041000167023 3

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/management-review.html

Management Review · No. 48 · November 2026 · Stiven Catalyst